

On a whim we planned to title this show Proustella de la Duchamp. We eventually decided to opt for a title that includes our program more explicitly within the context of the open studio day of the studiohouse Adw 11.

Proustella de la Duchamp

In 2003 I decided to read Proust. It took me seven years. I read it in French, at breakfast, for about half an hour. And I have to say it was one of the best seven years in my entire life. And as those of you who have read Proust know, the interval of reading proust is immediately followed by something else, that I call the desert of after Proust. It's the space of life where all you want is for Proust to go on. But there is no more. And so for a while you kind of make do with other sorts of reading materials; biographies and literary studies of Proust, and word indexes and books of other people who write kind of similarly to Proust. And it's all futile. There is no more Proust and that's that. Eventually you accept that and settle back into the grey tidium of a life without Proust.

I confess that I have not read Proust. I am the one laying in bed with the duvet tucked between my knees and my arms. He is on the other side of the bed. Lying on his stomach with a thick hardcover book. It is bound in leather and has a golden embossing. It feels old and worn like a bible. It is open and laying above his pillow as he is nervously reading. He is running his thumb nail repetitively between his front teeth. Only taking pauses to let both thumb and index fingertips slide back and forth under his nostrils. I had a friend when I for a brief and delirious moment was studying philosophy. And he would call out pretentiousness by saying that an argument or claim was cheap. And it was really good how he would say it. And as I am lying there in bed, squinting my eyes at the Proust reader, I think of my own cheapness. I have to tame my undernourished ego's impulses to mock him. But I know that the next time this Proust-reader will want to mock one of my habits. I have a new one right up my sleeve: Proustella de la Duchamp. This group show is not intended to deal with Proust nor Duchamp. It's a silly title. It's meant as a loving slur. A nickname for a show which is actually made up in a very simple way. The three contributing artists are from inhouse Adw 11. They were invited to show, under the condition that they invite an artist from outside of Basel. Then one of the artists, the one who reads Proust, additionally invited the inviter.

Olivia Vidovic